Source: ECI data. Analysis by Nalin Mehta, Rishabh Srivastava, PollNiti.

The BJP's New Catchment Areas of Bengal and Karnataka Are Also Driven by Rurban, Rural Growth

Interestingly, this phenomenon is not restricted to the Hindi heartland. Even in the BJP's new catchment areas in the South (Karnataka) and in the East (West Bengal), almost all of the party's growth is primarily in rurban and rural areas. In Karnataka, it won 91.3 per cent of rurban Lok Sabha seats in 2019, all of them with greater than 40 per cent vote share. The BJP won three of these seats, with more than 60 per cent of the votes, thirteen with more than 50 per cent of the votes and five with more than 40 per cent vote share. Just as in the northern Hindi heartland, Karnataka saw a deepening of the BJP's rurban base in the decade of 2009–2019. We see the early stages of this same pattern of growth in West Bengal, where the party won 56.6 per cent rural seats and 41 per cent rurban seats in the 2019 general election. Here, too, it scored more than 40 per cent vote share in ten rural and ten rurban seats each.[5]

The BJP's rise in rurban and rural areas under Modi and Shah signifies a return to its initial growth patterns of the early 1990s, when it first became a dominant force on the back of the Ayodhya agitation. Except, it is now evident on a much wider scale in the Hindi heartland and UP, while also being replicated in the new catchment areas of Karnataka and West Bengal. 'This is a very important and interesting phenomenon. Rurban areas, in particular, are a cradle for aspirations: both economic and social,' Jai Mrug argued as we discussed these findings. 'Rurban areas are home to a putative middle class, for which the BJP has always held an appeal. The population balance in rurban areas is such that there will always be a socio-economic aspiration for upward mobility because some urban-like people are always there—people who are better off than most average voters actually. Historically, the BJP first grew in the cities, but its real expansion from the 1980s was in the rurban areas, which became its bastions. Rurban vote bases have always been more steady and solid in Indian politics, compared to urban bases